Modi, though, didn't want to take any chances. He wanted the announcement to be made as soon as possible and was looking for an occasion to drive home the point. In June, he had tried to use the Uttarakhand floods to make a pitch as the ideal crisis manager, parking himself in Dehradun for three days. A local BJP spokesperson had suggested that Modi had played a pivotal role in 'rescuing' as many as 15,000 stranded Gujaratis. The *Times of India* went a step further, likening Modi to Rambo, the all-powerful cinematic character. At a time when the nation was grieving, when the security forces were working round the clock on rescue missions, the self-publicity backfired. Modi was the butt of Rambo jokes.

Modi blamed the media for the controversy. While the Rambo remark was perhaps a typical journalistic exaggeration, my sources in the BJP said that the original 'great rescue' theme had been pushed by the chief minister's publicists. When I spoke to Modi about it, his response was predictably combative. *'Lagta hai aaj kal tum logon ko koi aur news nahi hai!'* (Looks like you people have no other news these days.)

Now Modi was looking for another big national event to boost his PM credentials. The 15th of August, Independence Day, provided Modi with just that special moment. The prime minister's Red Fort address is an Independence Day ritual. The country's VIPs gather to show off their privileges. The rest of us are meant to listen to the prime minister listing out his achievements and plans for the future. On a cloudy August morning, Dr Singh was delivering his tenth, and possibly final, Independence Day speech. The economist PM was, self-admittedly, not a great public speaker. He was, in fact, a pretty poor one. The 2013 speech was no different. Dr Singh droned on monotonously for about forty minutes about the UPA's track record over a decade in government—from RTI to NREGA to the proposed food security bill, he pressed all the usual buttons in a rather perfunctory manner. By 8.45 a.m., the speech was over; the VIPs began to disperse, and the news desk still struggled for a headline. We didn't have to wait long.